

HOPLITE ARMOUR AND WEAPONS

For four centuries from 700BCE, heavily armed citizen-soldiers called hoplites (“armed men”) formed the armies of the Greek city-states. Each soldier typically provided all of his weaponry and armour at his own expense: a bronze corselet (made up of a bell-shaped breastplate and backplate), a helmet, greaves, a sword, a spear, and a large round shield. Fighting in tightly packed phalanxes, the soldiers were very well protected, although still vulnerable to spear-thrusts around the groin and throat, or to wounds inflicted by missiles before they closed in on the opposing army’s line.



Cheek guard

◀ CORINTHIAN HELMET

Date Late 7th century BCE

Origin Greece

Material Bronze

The Corinthian was the most common form of hoplite helmet, made from a single piece of bronze. It protected the whole head, with only a T-shaped opening for the eyes, nose, and mouth. An inner lining helped cushion the wearer’s head.

Moulding to represent warrior’s muscles

▶ LATE CORINTHIAN HELMET

Date 6th century BCE

Origin Greece

Material Bronze

More developed Corinthian helmets, such as this example, had sharply angled side pieces and thinner, more delicate nose protectors with a more pronounced neck guard. It is the type of helmet most commonly depicted on Corinthian vases.



Single bronze piece forms helmet

Shaped to fit contours of leg



Hinged cheekflap

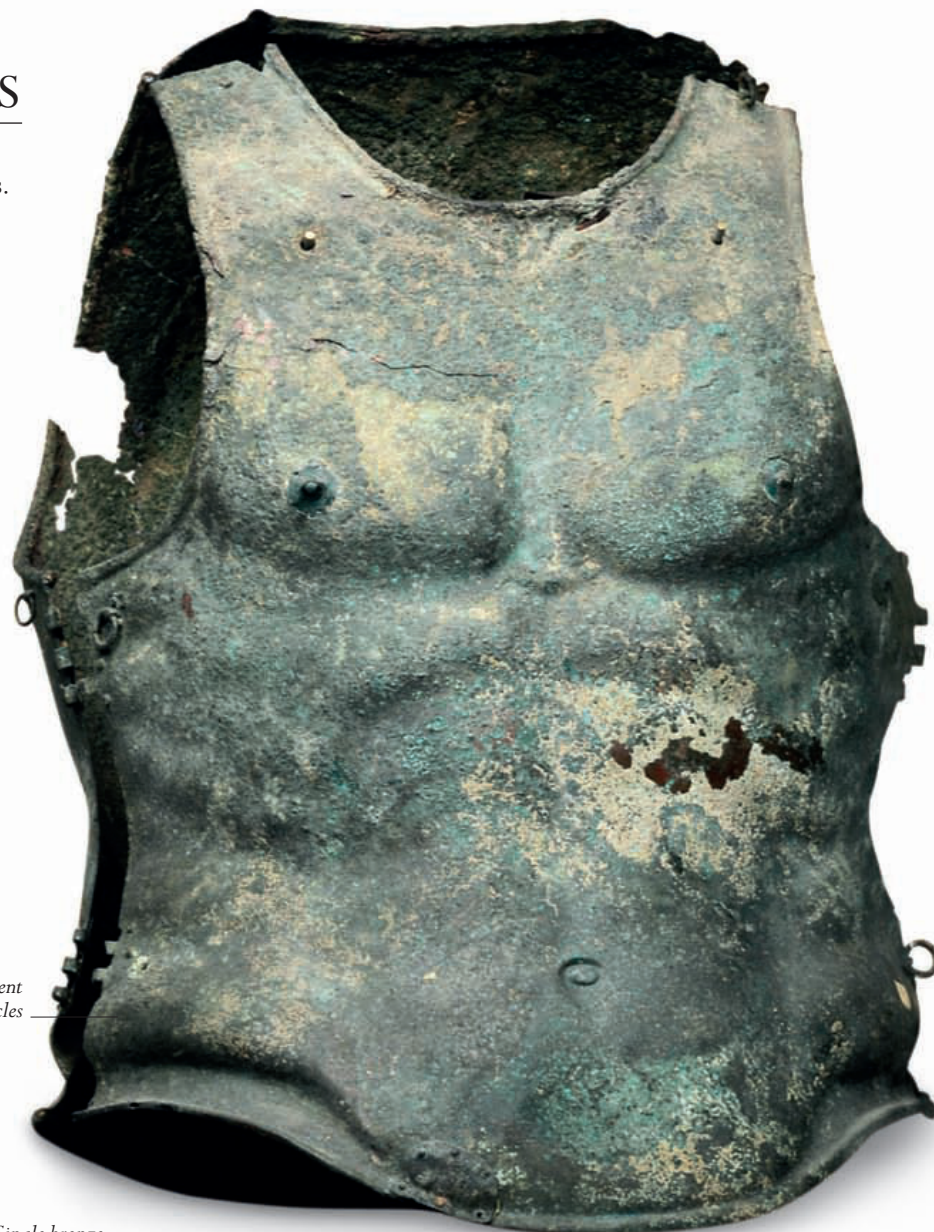
◀ ATTIC HELMET

Date 5th century BCE

Origin Greece

Material Bronze

The Attic helmet was a further development of the Chalcidian – a type that had more rounded cheekpieces than the Corinthian. However, the Attic gave lighter protection, with more space around the ears and hinged cheekflaps. It was often decorated on the front above the forehead.



▲ BRONZE CUIRASS

Date 8th century BCE

Origin Greece

Material Bronze

The backplate of the hoplite cuirass was secured to the front with hinges and rings for leather straps. The front was moulded to the contours of the wearer’s torso, suggesting that these cuirasses were probably crafted for individuals. Full plate cuirasses fell out of fashion around 500BCE.



◀ BRONZE GREAVES

Date 6th century BCE

Origin Greece

Material Bronze

While the hoplite’s thighs were covered by his shield, the greaves protected the knees and shins. The greaves were thin and shaped to the wearer’s legs, allowing them to be snapped into place without the need for straps or ties.